



CAMEROON

Capital city: Yaoundé**Area:** 183,567 sq miles
(475,400 sq km)**Population:** 16,000,000**Official languages:**
French, English**Major religions:**
Christian 53%, traditional
beliefs 25%, Muslim 22%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** CFA franc**Adult literacy rate:** 68%**Life expectancy:** 48 years**People per doctor:** 10,000**Televisions:** 32 per 1,000
people

CAMEROON

IN AN AREA THAT HAS SEEN many troubles since independence, Cameroon is a relatively prosperous and stable success story thanks to sensible government policies. Along with its southern neighbors, Gabon and Congo, the country has earned money from oil and has used this to develop its economy. Many different peoples live in Cameroon, and its geography is just as varied. The humid coastal plain in the south gives way to a drier central plateau, while a finger of land points up to the marshes around Lake Chad.



Pearl millet grows to a height of 5–10 ft (1.5–3 m).



Women grind and sieve the millet grains to make a coarse flour.



Millet can also be used to make beer. It is dried, pounded, and then brewed in large pots.



A stiff white porridge made from millet flour is a popular breakfast dish.



PEOPLES

With more than 130 ethnic groups, Cameroon has one of the richest mixes of peoples in Africa. These range from the Fulani cattle herders, who live in the north and follow Islamic beliefs, to forest dwellers farther south, who practice traditional religions. Most people are settled farmers producing enough for their own needs, like this Hausa farmer tending his cattle.

GROWING MILLET

Most farmers in Cameroon grow some crops, such as millet, for their own use (subsistence farming), but also produce crops to sell. Millet is cultivated widely in northern Cameroon, where there is less rainfall, because it grows well in poorer, drier soils. There has also been great investment in the production of commercial “cash” crops such as cocoa and coffee, oil palms, and bananas.



The gourds vibrate when the strings are plucked or a piece of wood is drawn across them.

This bow is basically a wooden stick with strings stretched down its length and dried, hollowed-out gourds placed at intervals.

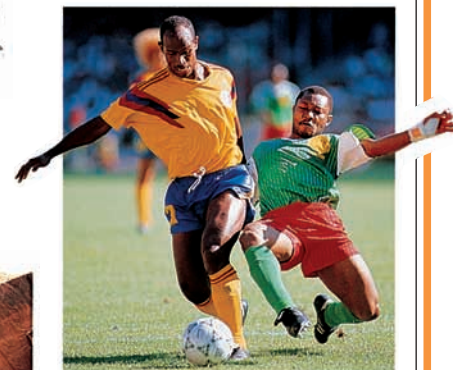
MUSIC

Traditional musical instruments of all shapes and sizes, such as this bow, can be heard in villages up and down the country. The most popular style of folk music in Cameroon is *makossa*, which mixes African sounds and soul music, and its lively rhythms are perfect to dance to. *Makossa* is widely enjoyed by people all over central Africa.



INDUSTRY

Cameroon has an expanding logging industry. The country has extensive forests, and mahogany, ebony, and teak are all exported abroad. However, the industry is hampered by roads that are impassable during the rainy season. Much of the country's wealth is based on its reserves of oil, and other natural resources include bauxite, iron, and gold.



SOCCER

Cameroon has one of Africa's most celebrated soccer teams, known for some spectacular displays of skill on home territory and in the World Cup. The people of Cameroon love soccer – at lunchtime and in the evenings informal games spring up on any spare piece of open ground.

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